

English News Hub | Professor Biao Xiang: The Unlikely Celebrity Helping Anxious Young People (27th September 2026)

1. Vocabulary Focus

Match the words on the left with their correct definitions on the right:

- | | |
|------------------------|---|
| 1. Unexpected ____ | A. Very tired |
| 2. Anthropologist ____ | B. Things that you are scared of |
| 3. Developed ____ | C. Advanced |
| 4. Career ____ | D. Concerns, preoccupations |
| 5. Degree ____ | E. Surprising |
| 6. Exhausted ____ | F. A course at university |
| 7. Worries ____ | G. Someone who studies human behaviour |
| 8. Fears ____ | H. A person's professional jobs |

2. Reading Text

Read the article and underline any new words or expressions.

A 54-year-old university professor has become an unexpected celebrity among young people in China. Professor Biao Xiang is not a pop star or an actor. He is an anthropologist who studies society and social change. However, thousands of young people are now following his talks and treating him almost like an idol.

The reason for his popularity is simple: he talks openly about anxiety and the pressure young people have. China has developed very quickly, but this has also created a lot of competition. Young people worry about finding a good job, having a good career, relationships and being able to afford a home.

The transition from school to working life can be especially difficult. Many people feel that they must get a good degree, find a secure job, get married and buy a house. Because so many people are competing for the same things, they can feel exhausted and worried about not being successful.

Professor Xiang believes that people often depend too much on exams, jobs and other systems to decide how successful they are. Instead, he encourages young people to understand themselves and find meaning in their relationships with others.

For many of his young fans, Xiang is important because he makes them feel understood. His unusual popularity shows how much young people want someone to talk honestly about their worries and fears.

(Adapted from bbc.com)

Comprehension & Discussion

3. Reading Comprehension

Answer the questions based on the text:

1. Who is Professor Biao Xiang?

.....

2. Why do young people like his talks?

.....

3. What topics does he discuss?

.....

4. How is he different from other celebrities?

.....

4. Discussion & Celebrity "Hot Takes"

Discuss these statements with a partner. Do you agree or disagree?

- **Statement 1:** *"The concept of traditional celebrities (actors and pop stars) is disappearing, and younger generations are looking up to everyday experts instead."*
- **Statement 2:** *"It is positive for young people to have famous role models who talk openly about their mental health and anxiety."*
- **Statement 3:** *"Being successful is no longer about making a lot of money or becoming famous."*

5. Final Debate Task

Choose one of the topics below to debate with your partner. Try to use the opinion phrases provided.

• Topic 1: <i>Celebrities have a social responsibility to use their fame to help young people with anxiety.</i> • Topic 2: <i>Young people today should worry less about having a successful career and focus more on personal happiness.</i>	Useful Phrases for Giving Opinions: • In my opinion... • The way I see it... • As far as I'm concerned... • From my point of view...
---	--